

Minnesota Unified Certification Program (MNUCP)

Overview

The Minnesota Unified Certification Program (MNUCP) is the state's certification program for minority, women, and disadvantaged business enterprises (MWD BE). This program provides a single certification that is recognized by the State of Minnesota and participating local agencies, including many metropolitan area counties and cities.

Program Benefits

- Single certification recognized by multiple agencies
- Access to state and local government contracting opportunities
- Participation in set-aside programs and contract goals
- Networking and business development opportunities
- Technical assistance and mentorship programs

Certification Categories

1. **Minority Business Enterprise (MBE)**: Businesses at least 51% owned by minority individuals
2. **Women Business Enterprise (WBE)**: Businesses at least 51% owned by women
3. **Disadvantaged Business Enterprise (DBE)**: Businesses owned by socially and economically disadvantaged individuals
4. **Emerging Small Business Enterprise (ESBE)**: Small businesses owned by any ethnicity

Eligibility Requirements

Ownership and Control Requirements

- At least 51% ownership by qualifying individuals (for MBE/WBE)
- Social and economic disadvantage (for DBE)
- U.S. citizenship requirement for owners
- Day-to-day management and control by certified owners
- Independence from other firms

Business Requirements

- Legitimate business concern
- Located in Minnesota or provide substantial benefit to Minnesota
- Adequate financial capacity and business capability
- Personal net worth limitations (excluding business equity and primary residence)

Application Process

1. **Pre-Application:** Review requirements and gather documentation
2. **Application Submission:** Complete application with required documents
3. **Document Review:** Verification of ownership, control, and business eligibility
4. **Site Visit:** On-site inspection of business operations
5. **Interview:** Potential interview with owners
6. **Committee Review:** Evaluation by certification committee
7. **Notification:** Decision communicated to applicant
8. **Directory Listing:** Inclusion in certified business directory

Required Documentation

- Completed application form
- Personal financial statements for all owners
- Business financial statements and tax returns
- Organizational documents (articles, operating agreements)
- Banking resolutions and account statements
- Insurance certificates
- Business licenses and permits
- Lease agreements or property ownership documents
- Affidavits of ownership and control
- Narrative statement of business operations

Certification Benefits for JAM Construction

Market Access

- State of Minnesota construction and professional services contracts
- Metropolitan area county contracts (Hennepin, Ramsey, etc.)
- Participating city contracts beyond Minneapolis
- Port authority and transit authority projects
- Educational institution contracts

Competitive Advantages

- Access to MWDBE set-aside contracts
- Contract goal participation opportunities
- Prime contractor subcontracting opportunities
- Joint venture partnerships with larger firms
- Mentor protégé program participation

Recertification Requirements

- Annual reporting and compliance verification
- Update of financial and business information

- Confirmation of continued eligibility
- Site visit re-verification every 3 years

Timeline

- Application to certification: 60-90 days
- Recertification: Every 1-3 years depending on circumstances

Application Strategy for JAM Construction

1. **Determine Appropriate Category:** Select MBE, WBE, DBE, or ESBE based on ownership
2. **Document Preparation:** Gather all required financial and business documents
3. **Application Submission:** Submit complete application to avoid delays
4. **Follow-up:** Respond promptly to any requests for additional information
5. **Marketing Plan:** Develop strategy to reach agencies and prime contractors
6. **Network Building:** Attend MNUCP-sponsored events and workshops

Related Programs

- SBA 8(a) Business Development Program (federal)
- MN Department of Transportation DBE Program (federal requirements)
- Local certification programs (may be required in addition to MNUCP)

Resources

- MNUCP website: mnucp.org
- Application portal and requirements
- Upcoming workshops and information sessions
- Certified business directory
- Technical assistance resources

The MNUCP certification provides access to a broader market than the Minneapolis SUBE program alone, including state government contracts and other participating agencies throughout Minnesota.